

THE
GLORY OF GRACE
Effected by weak Means

by
John Church

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GRACE EFFECTED BY WEAK MEANS ***

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THE *GLORY OF GRACE*

Effected by weak Means:

BEING THE SUBSTANCE OF

A SERMON,

PREACHED ON THE

DEATH OF SAMUEL CHURCH,

Aged Twelve Years.

On SUNDAY Evening, APRIL 14, 1822,

BY J. CHURCH,

At the Surrey Tabernacle.

And Eli perceived that the Lord had called the Child.—1 *Sam.* iii, 8.

And there is hope in thine end, saith the LORD, that thy Children shall
come
again to their own Border.—*Jeremiah xxxi*, 17.

SOUTHWARK,

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1822.

A SERMON, &c.

Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings hast thou ordained strength, because of thine enemies, that thou mightest still the enemy and the avenger. *Psalm viii, 2.*

WHEN David had his mind most divinely elevated and filled with holy thoughts of the person, work, and glory of the dear Redeemer, he burst forth in holy admiration, joy, and praise, in this adoring language: I will extol thee, my God, O king! I will bless thy name for ever and ever! One generation shall praise thy works unto another, and shall declare thy mighty acts: and surely the most wonderful and astonishing act, is the everlasting salvation of lost, ruined, guilty man. This is a greater act than the formation of worlds, either heaven or earth. The salvation of one poor sinner is a more marvellous display of God, than the creation, with all its wonders. This salvation we are to speak of to others, both ministers and people; and in proportion as we see our interest in it, so are we to declare its greatness, because it is the highest act of God, as the God of all grace, and

Why should the wonders he has wrought
Be lost in silence and forgot?

But babes, men, and children, let them praise the name of the Lord.

I could wish this task, on this solemn, and to me, painful occasion, had devolved on one suitable, but supported by the Lord's presence, upheld by his power, and cheered with his approbation in my mind, I humbly attempt to rehearse the wonders of his love, the riches of his grace, and the displays of his mercy to me, and mine, and attempt, in my poor way, to prove the glorious truth in the text: Out of the mouths of babes God has ordained his own glory, the glory of his *love*, his *grace*, his *mercy*, his *truth*, his *power*, his *faithfulness*, and infinite *condescension*. It is true that I can do no

justice to the important words, by way of a Sermon. They contain a vast store of rich truth and precious experience. I must therefore merely glance at the meaning, and shew, in as concise a manner as I can, to whom they belong, and to whom they will, with scriptural propriety, apply.

The title of this psalm is to the chief musician upon Gittith, a psalm of David.—Various are the conjectures of learned men on this title. Some think the word Gittith signifies the wine press, and the title means, To the conqueror over the trodden wine press, wrath; and if so, we are not at a loss to know to whom it belongs. A psalm of, or concerning the beloved one, to whom be glory. Amen.

The ever blessed Redeemer is the subject of this psalm. Hence we find it quoted in the New Testament, and twice applied to him. It is a revelation of Christ, as God-man, in his headship, his empire, dominion, and excellent name, his royalties, majesty, and glory, with his union, relation, and interest in his people. It is addressed to him as Jehovah, the covenant God of the church; as one of the glorious and divine persons, subsisting in the divine essence, with the Father and the holy Spirit, the incomprehensible God, the most high God, blessed for evermore; the mighty God, the everlasting Father, the first and the last. If the first, there were none before him, and if the last, there can be none after him. He is the Almighty, himself has declared it; the true God and eternal life, possessing every divine and glorious perfection, the maker of heaven and earth, the centre, the foundation, the glory, the beauty, and ornament of creation; and the whole is sustained by him—he is omnipotent, omniscient, omnipresent, eternal, unchangeable—the adorable I am, that I am!—and as God in covenant, as well as absolute deity, he is called our God, your God, their God, my Lord, and my God, the most mighty, the great God, the living God; and must not that person have diabolical effrontery to deny the essential and eternal Godhead of the Lord Jesus Christ? Such conduct clearly demonstrates that such persons are in nature's thickest gloom, nor can those characters give the church or the world any scriptural account of the holy Spirit's work upon their hearts. We, therefore, can never allow such unconverted persons to be proper judges of any one truth in divine revelation. When persons are called by divine grace, they are brought to feel their need of just such a saviour as Christ is, and are led to prize the infinite value of his blood, the merit of his obedience, the power of his arm, and the love of his heart. But

amidst the host of enemies to the person and dignity of Christ, we humbly and gratefully unite with the Psalmist: Oh Lord, our Lord, how excellent is thy name in all the earth, thy perfections, and thy gospel, wherever it has been carried. And how glorious it will be in the new heavens and earth, during the millennium, his thousand years personal reign with his people. There *he* has set his glory above the heavens, his everlasting love, his holy humanity; and his church, as considered in himself, are exalted above the ærial or starry heavens. This is his glory, the joy of the redeemed, the wonder of elect angels, and the envy of devils.

The Psalmist, having been led to adore Jehovah Jesus, as God in covenant, and as God-man, the brightness of the Father's glory, is sweetly brought on to view him in his humiliation, final victory, and exaltation; and while considering the heavenly bodies, their glory and greatness, with his own insufficiency to celebrate his power, he yet adores him for that knowledge with which his mind was favored, and exclaims, What is man that thou art mindful of him? This passage is quoted by the apostle, and the whole of it is applied to Christ, as the mediator, as the Son of man, admiring that grace which conferred so great an honor upon him, as to choose his individual nature, his humanity, as to unite it with the Godhead, that he should prepare it in the covenant, anoint it with the oil of gladness above his fellows, delight in it, exalt it, and take such providential care of it; support it under his direful sorrows, raise it, and give it glory. Thus the sacred Messiah is represented, as filled with holy and admiring thoughts of the subject, and in extacy asks, What is man? the human nature made a little lower than God, but next unto him, and in personal union with the Son of God; a little lower than the angels for the suffering of death, but crowned with glory and honor, as the whole election of grace, and as the mediator of reconciliation. Christ by delegation, hath universal dominion over all things, visible and invisible, nature, providence, grace, glory, earth, and hell; and this will ever form a subject for the admiration of God's people. O Lord, our Lord, how excellent is thy name in all the earth! for as thou hast formed thy people for thy praise, thou hast ordained the wonders of thy grace shall be celebrated by them in time and eternity. Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings thou hast ordained strength, because of thine enemies, that thou mightest still the enemy and the avenger.

We may consider these words as justly applicable to 1. David. 2, David's Lord.—3, The children of the temple. 4, The apostles in their minority.—5, The experience of believers.—6, The salvation of children. This good man was chosen and ordained for the glory of God, and for the benefit of his people; eternally chosen in Christ to salvation; he was impressed with the power of converting grace in very early life, and long before he was introduced to public notice, long before his elevation to the throne of Israel. No doubt, while a youth, the holy Spirit took possession of his heart, and led his mind to hope in the promised Messiah, for life and salvation, and being selected from the busy world, and the cares, vanities, and snares of the court, he had many sweet moments in the sacred enjoyment of his God. *Times*, his mind often afterwards reflected upon with heaven-felt pleasure. It appears God had endowed him with astonishing skill in music, and a sublime talent for poetry, so that he probably filled his leisure hours with close attention to the exercise of those gifts; and as Mr. Toplady strikingly remarks, on David's composing this beautiful pastoral psalm: We must form to ourselves an idea of David, the stripling, and think we see him watching his flocks on a summer's night, under the expanded canopy of the skies. The air is still, the heavens are serene, the moon arrived at her full, is pursuing her majestic silent course, the stars, like peeresses, on a coronation solemnity, assume their brightest robes, to attend the beauteous sovereign of the night, while both moon and stars concur to shed a soft undazzling lustre on all the subjacent landscape. David, at this happy period, a blameless youth, unpoisoned with ambition, and unfacinated by the witchcraft of court corruption, and his hands undipped in blood, is seated on a rising hillock, or on the protuberant root of some stately tree. All is hushed, not a bough rustles, not a leaf trembles to the breeze; the silent flocks are either carelessly grazing by his side, or slumbering securely at his feet. The birds have suspended their songs, until waked by the superior sweetness of his voice, and the music of his hand; for, charmed with the loveliness of the scene, and wrapt by the holy Spirit into a seraphic flame of exalted devotion, he has lain aside his crook—he has taken up his harp, and transmitting to the throne of God, these grateful, these inexpressibly beautiful lines contained in this psalm, this divine testimony of Jesus, although perhaps wrote more than a thousand years before his incarnation. David's mind was illuminated with spiritual knowledge, his faith centering in the Messiah, his hope resting on his covenant engagements, his affections

cleaving to him, his mind at this time, happy in his love; and astonished at the infinite condescension of the God of all grace, in looking upon him in early life; saving him from the follies of youth, converting his soul, anointing him though a stripling, to be a king; working deliverance for him, when by a supernatural power upon him, he slew a lion at one time, and a bear at another. Surely as his heart glowed at the reflection, his mouth spoke forth the high praises of the Lord; and as God was his strength, so he had ordained the effects of it for the glory of his own name, that he might be praised and adored, and that the enemies of the Lord and his people might be confounded. This was frequently the case in the wars of David, but particularly while a stripling; and in comparison to men of war, he was but a babe or suckling, when he went to meet Goliath, the gigantic champion of the Philistines, who for forty days gave a challenge to decide the fate of the war by a single combat, defying them to produce a man in the whole army of Israel that dare engage him. The Lord stirred up the mind of this pious youth, this shepherd's boy, the son of Jesse, to attack this unwieldy monster, near eleven feet high, and covered with brass. David, armed with divine power and skill, and encouraged by his God, went forth to meet the insulting foe, and slung a stone, which being divinely directed, sunk into his forehead, and brought him to the ground. Surely, in reading the whole history, we may see the text evidently fulfilled, and sweetly confirmed; but surely, if the power, glory, and faithfulness of God were so eminently seen in the victory given to this babe; out of whose mouth God was glorified, and his enemies stilled, silenced, overcome, and defeated, how much more so in the instance of David's Lord, who having taken our nature into union with his divine person, is called the Holy Child, Jesus, (Acts iv, 27) by whom God had ordained his highest glory, the honor of all his perfections, in a way of grace, in the salvation of innumerable millions. And are we not often led to contemplate the appearance of this holy child? When but a babe, as it were, we find him in the temple, disputing with the learned doctors there, hearing them, and asking them questions about many points in the laws of Moses, and probably many important questions concerning the promised Messiah; and all that heard him were astonished at his understanding, and answers. Out of his sacred lips God ordained his *truth*, his *word*, his *will* should be known. May we not see this accomplished by the mouth of his ministry, miracles, praises, and prayers? And those who were taught of God, wondered at the gracious words which proceeded out

of his mouth. His lips were like lilies, dropping sweet-smelling myrrh, when he opened his mouth and taught, and blest his people. Every doctrine he preached, every invitation he gave, every truth he taught, every declaration he made, every word he spoke, was truly blessed, of everlasting importance, and for the glory of God. His prayers and intercessions for his dear people were ever prevalent with God, while every tear he shed, every sigh he heaved, every groan he uttered, every stripe, and every pain, with every drop of blood which he shed, were as so many mouths pleading for all who believe in him; and now he lives in glory, he appears before the throne in the full virtue and dignity of his sacrifice and obedience, pleading for all that come to God through him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession with God for them. By his infinitely meritorious obedience to the law, and by his bearing its dreadful penalties, he stilled the avenger, the curse of a broken law, and the insulted justice of God. He made full satisfaction by enduring the curse, being made a curse for us, so that the threatening being thus executed upon the surety, and justice satisfied, it can no longer pursue that poor sinner, who flies to the city of refuge, to lay hold on the hope set before him; and this city is divinely set forth in these blessed Scriptures: A man shall be as an hiding place from the wind, a refuge from the storm. The eternal God is thy refuge. Christ, God-man, mediator, is the refuge. Here the righteous flee, and are safe from the avenger of blood. God, revealed in a broken law, is an enemy to sinners as such, just as a judge is to a guilty criminal; but when viewed as reconciled, and well pleased we see him well pleased with us in him; the Father looks upon us in Christ, views us holy, and pronounces us righteous; as a man looking up a wall, or on any object through a red glass, it appears red; so are we view in Christ. Ye are complete in him, having forgiven us all trespasses—Christ having finish the work, overcome all enemies, disappointed Satan, bruised his head, and took away his power; drew the envenomed dart of death, barred the mouth of hell from his people, overcome the grave; put an end to sin, and triumphed over death in his own dominions; he has for ever stilled the enemy and the avenger, and fulfilled the purposes, and gracious decrees of God, respecting the redemption of his chosen. Worthy is the lamb that was slain! how great his love, how infinite his condescension, how eminent his victories, but how dreadful an evil must sin be,

How damnable must sin appear,
If we reflect how dear
It cost the Saviour to atone
For all our weight of guilt,
For sin his precious blood was spilt.

This scripture was also divinely fulfilled, when our Lord rode in triumph to Jerusalem, as related by the evangelist. Having sent two of his disciples to fetch him an ass and a colt, he sat thereon. While vast multitudes were collected, and attended him in the way to the city, some laid their cloaths on the beast, others cast them on the ground for him to ride over, and many cut down branches of palm trees to adorn his entrance into the city, the children in the temple sung their hosannas to the Redeemer, in harmony with the loud shouts and acclamations of the populace. The Pharisees, those most inveterate enemies of Christ, who had been a little mortified just before, by the display of the power and Godhead of Christ, in raising Lazarus from the dead, were still more so, on beholding the triumphant entrance of Jesus, the approbation of the people, and the anthem of the children. They had the daring effrontery to ask him, hearest thou what those children say? The Saviour said, And did you never read, that out of the mouths of babes and sucklings thou hast perfected praise? Here was the real literal fulfilment of this text, for the Redeemer on this occasion, stilled and silenced those enemies and avengers. This triumphant entrance was indeed an emblem of his future exaltation. The animal which bore Him perhaps intended to shew the characters he would make use of to bear his name in the Jewish and Gentile worlds, and amongst all persons, high and low, rich and poor, learned and illiterate. The conduct of the people in casting their cloaths from them, to shew the effect that grace has upon the heart, in causing the soul to renounce its own righteousness, as more fit for the feet of an ass, than to recommend it to God; while the branches of palms which they bore were ensigns of the future victories which the all-conquering captain of our salvation would gain over all his enemies. And the very songs of the children, the prayers, and the praises which would ascend from his redeemed in the temple of his church, in all future generations. Their hosannas were a prayer for salvation in all its branches—save Lord, I beseech thee! and it was a wishing success, and prosperity to his kingdom. These two are found together in the souls of the called children of God.

Where there is prayer for our own souls, there is an earnest desire for the increase of the Redeemer's kingdom, and a hearty welcoming his visits: Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord. This is the soul's echo to the pleasing tidings: Behold the king cometh unto thee. May not this group of children, singing the praises of the adorable Messiah, though perhaps unconscious of the meaning, be a beautiful figure of that vast body of children who are saved by his grace, and shout his fame, his love, and his victories, in the temple of heaven for ever.

Babes, thither caught from womb and breast,
Claim'd right to sing above the rest,
Because they found that happy shore
They never saw nor sought before.

And surely God has ordained the praise of his own grace in the salvation of children, and this will be confessed for ever by them, to the eternal confusion of those who live and die despisers of salvation by grace. Here, such enemies will be confounded in beholding the freeness, the sovereignty, riches, and victories of electing, redeeming, calling, and glorifying grace: for Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings thou hast ordained strength, because of thine enemies.

I humbly conceive this beautiful passage may, with propriety, be applied to the apostles, and first ministers of our Lord. This was a name he was pleased to them. The great head of the church having chosen his twelve apostles, it pleased him to call and appoint seventy disciples besides, in allusion to Moses choosing twelve princes and seventy elders in the wilderness. The Lord Jesus sent them out two by two, and giving them power to preach the kingdom of God, and to heal the sick, they went forth and did as Jesus commanded them. Upon their return, and laying their labours at his feet, astonished at their success, that it exceeded their expectations, even to the casting out of devils. At that time Jesus rejoiced in spirit, and said, I thank thee, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes—even so Father, for so it seemed good in thy sight. These ministers of Christ are called babes, weak, ignorant, and foolish, when compared with what they should be after the day of Pentecost, or when compared with the wise ones of this world, men of great natural gifts,

wisdom, sagacity, penetration, and skill, in natural things; but these were babes in comparison to such knowing ones, and they were babes in their own esteem, weak, defenceless, impotent, dependent, and knowing little or nothing in their own opinion, yet humble, docile, and teachable, sitting at their master's feet, and looking to him for divine teaching. It was out of the mouths of these persons God had ordained the gospel to be preached, and this is called the rod of his strength—the power of God to salvation in every one that believeth. Their testimony was plain and simple, but it did wonders in the world. Nor can there be a greater proof of the divine authenticity of the word of God, than the work it has accomplished, for in the hands of the holy Spirit, and by the preaching of it, proud, profane, prejudiced, and carnal persons, have been humbled, subdued, quickened, illuminated, made holy, saved. The wolf has been brought to lay down at the feet of the Lamb of God, the cow and the bear. The ministers of Christ, and a raging tyrant by nature, have walked together! yea, a little child has led those fierce characters into all truth! (Isaiah xi.) Instrumentally, such enemies have been subdued, changed, and become distinguished monuments of sovereign, converting grace. The New Testament is full of those instances, and millions in heaven, and thousands upon earth, have felt the power of a gospel ministry. This is most strikingly remarked by the apostle: But if all prophecy, or preach, and there came in one that believeth not, or unlearned, he is convinced of all, judged of all, and thus are the secrets of his heart made manifest; and so falling down on his face he will worship, and report that God is in you of a truth, because the same Almighty power is put forth in the word, that called light out of darkness at the creation, and that called Lazarus from the tomb. Nothing short of this, can produce any good effect upon the understanding, the will, the affections, the mind, and conscience of a sinner. What powerful reproofs, cutting convictions, consoling influences, supporting and delivering power, have been felt by the Lord's people, in hearing and reading the gospel of Jesus, whether in the Old or the New Testament. And this has cast out Satan, and sin's dominion, tyranny, power guilt, and distress, from the soul; has answered many an accusation, freed from many a doubt, and overcome the enemy and the avenger. This is no small mortification to that implacable foe, to see the astonishing power and success of the gospel, and himself, at times, put to flight, by a simple act of faith in God's truth.

Oh! I have seen the day,
When with a single word,
God helping me to say
My trust is in the Lord;
My soul has slain a thousand foes,
Fearless of all that could oppose.

For so the promise runs, and so the victorious believer has found it. One of you shall chase a thousand (by the word,) and two of you (by faith and prayer), shall put ten thousand to flight.

Blessed be God for the gospel, and for its power and influence upon our hearts. This is the sweet evidence of our eternal election of God, for our gospel came not unto you in word only, but in power; in the Holy Ghost, and in much assurance. It is in this way, even a babe in Christ has stilled the enemy and the avenger. The people of the Most High are called babes; and little children, being born again, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, but of God—created anew in Christ Jesus, unto good works, which God hath before ordained, that we should walk in them. This new birth is produced by the almighty power of God, the holy making Spirit. It is an evidence of everlasting love, and of the soul's interest in the blood and righteousness of Christ; and none have any right to consider themselves in Christ, who are strangers to the new birth. It is the gracious indwelling of the holy Spirit in his divine influences—forming a new man of grace—a new heart—a right spirit, infusing every holy principle, in conformity to the image, of Christ. When this work is begun in most of God's children, it is hard to tell, but some blessed effects of it may be clearly seen. Such souls, may be long under the terror of the law, the bondage of their spirit, the fears of death, the dread of judgment, eternity and hell, yet the Lord hears their groans, sees their oppressions, tears, and fears, and will in due time, bring them out of prison. Some, indeed, are led on more smoothly, but none are left ignorant of their lost state by nature, their condemnation by the law, and the value of Christ, as the atonement and righteousness of his people. Such babes are humble, simple, sincere, and teachable; they desire the breast of consolation, from heart-felt misery; they desire the sincere milk of the word, not only the word, but the *milk* of it, that they may grow thereby into a deeper knowledge of Christ, till their faith is grown up to full assurance, and their hope big with expectations; till a sense of divine love casts out all

doubts and fears, which sadly torment their minds, and till they know the whole armour of God; and surely there can be no actual enjoyment with Christ, or entering into truth, or the privileges of the gospel, or into eternal glory, till this new birth takes place. There can be neither *seeing* nor *entering* the kingdom; there may be a superficial knowledge, and plenty of talk about truth; but it is a cordial reception of it in the heart, and digesting it in the mind, that will ever produce any good effect, either in the soul, or in the conversation. And except we become as little children, we can in no wise enter the kingdom; but having been blessed with this divine change in the heart, confession is to be made to the glory of God. This is the ordinance of Heaven: there is to be an acknowledgement of the truth, a declaration of what God has done for us to the church, to one another; and when prudent opportunity offers, before the world, by words, and by facts, open and visible, sincere and hearty, likewise in prayer; and praise, when the Lord is pleased to give us strength so to do, that others may be led to see that there is a reality in religion, and may be blessed with the strength of grace to seek the Lord, and glorify God in the day of their visitation: in so doing, you still the enemy, and by a God-glorifying conduct, put to silence the ignorance of foolish men, the enemies of God and truth. And where the conscience is made tender, every thing that is contrary to this, is a source of inconceivable grief. These babes are at times, also enabled to silence Satan himself, with all the accusations of a distressed and burdened conscience, when the atonement, obedience, love, person, offices and promises, invitations and faithfulness of the dear Redeemer is powerfully brought into the mind, by the holy Spirit, and strength given to baffle the enemy, with his satanic suggestions, as a young man did lately, upon his death bed, depending upon, and pleading the great work of Christ, for his acceptance with God, just going into eternity. The enemy plagued him with this question continually: 'Tis true Christ died for sinners! but how do you know he died for you? The young man had strength given him to answer the enemy as fast as he plagued him! But, Satan, how do you know he did not? Thus he gained the victory over the enemy, and died in sweet confidence. Thanks be to God, who giveth us the victory, for out of the mouths of such babes he has ordained his own glory. It is also evident, that God is glorified by the displays of the riches, power, and freeness of grace, in the salvation of children. This must be favor indeed, as such can perform no act of demotion to recommend them to God! nor can their innocence do

it, as they are conceived in sin, born, or shapen in iniquity, under the imputation of the guilt of Adam, and with the seeds of every sin in them that can be committed in this world, though guilty of no actual transgression, yet by nature they are sinners, destitute of the image of God, and under guilt. How great that grace which chose them—how infinitely dear that blood which redeemed them—and how condescending that holy Spirit that takes possession of them before their little souls leave their bodies: they are to be considered, passively, the capable subjects of converting grace—and who can tell what passes on the soul of a departing infant, under the operations of the spirit of God? Millions of infants are, doubtless, before the throne of God, and the Lamb, praising, adoring, and blessing that mercy that saved them so early, not on account of their natural purity, nor their religious descent—not because their parents were pious persons, for this can make no difference—nor because they were superstitiously baptized, as it is erroneously called, but because God has set his love upon them—because they are interested in the covenant of grace—because the Redeemer has died for them—his righteousness is imputed to them—and because the holy Spirit takes possession of their hearts—sanctifies them in a moment—and because God has ordained the glory of himself, in the everlasting salvation and happiness of those who are not able to save themselves. I acknowledge the salvation of all infants has been a subject of dispute, amongst many, and Satan has taken the advantage to distress many a parent upon the subject. But secret things belong to the Lord, our God, the things that are revealed belong to us. Here we want grace to rest, yet I am bold to affirm, that we have no one solid proof of the everlasting destruction of an infant. It is no where positively *asserted* nor yet *implied*. I am now speaking of babes. Millions have been destroyed in public calamities, and died a corporeal death, but not punished with an everlasting death; nor can we find any infants amongst those of whom it is affirmed, that they suffer the vengeance of eternal fire. It was David's consolation that his child was saved, though born under adulterous circumstances. I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me. This does not refer to the grave, for there could be but little pleasure in that thought, but to eternal rest. The pious Shunamite woman said of the death of her son, It is well. And the Lord promised that that son of Jereboam should go to his grave, because in that child there was found some good thing toward the Lord God of Israel. Thousands of dear children were massacred by

order of Herod, with an intent to murder the Redeemer. These dear children were the first martyrs for Christ, and the Lord assures us of their salvation, (Jeremiah xxxi, 15, 16, 17.) to which I refer you. The *border* there spoken of, is most undoubtedly the millennium, the heavenly country, where these precious stones would adorn the crown of the Redeemer, and be everlasting monuments of the wonders of his grace. These dear children will to eternity, acknowledge how infinitely indebted they are to the adorable trinity in unity, for so great a salvation.

And now they range the heavenly plains,
And sing his love in melting strains;
Or, overwhelm'd with rapture sweet,
Sink down adoring at his feet.

I come now to speak of the closing scene of my much-loved son. On this subject I want much fortitude and power from on high, to sustain my deeply affected heart. None but God knows the strange mixture of my feelings, grief and gratitude, sorrow and wonder. I have not room here to enlarge on the subject of nature and affection, and the feelings these ties inspire in the loss of one so dear to my heart. Cruel memory recalls to mind a thousand endearments, in such departed worth, but I fall at the footstool of divine mercy, and bless the God of all grace, that I am not sorrowing as one without hope. Many whom I am now addressing, knew him well, and all who knew him loved him. He was beloved of his God—blest from infancy with peculiar powers, which no doubt would have shown brightly in life, had he been spared. But though the subject of deep affliction, yet grace shone in his mind, and its radiance was sweetly emitted to an eminent manner, as his afflictions abounded. He was the last son of his dear mother, who is in glory; and being favored at his birth with a peculiar answer to prayer, I adopted the method of ancient believers, on extraordinary occasions, and called him Samuel, *heard of God!* and so he proved to be. About six years ago, he broke his leg, which afterwards produced great weakness through the fright; the pain, and long confinement. This had a serious effect upon his whole mass of blood, which afterwards shewed itself in several abscesses. These baffled all the skill of medicine, and though well attended by medical persons, and most tenderly and carefully nursed,

and watched by day and by night, yet God had determined to bring him to glory, at nearly twelve years of age, nor can I wish him back again.

To be with dire afflictions tost and tore,
The suffering little boy he was before!

But during the last months he was with his kind affectionate, attentive Aunt and Uncle, who have been long in the ways of God, and have had a most clear and blessed experience of grace and truth themselves, they were often highly delighted to see the work of grace so eminently displayed in their dear little suffering nephew. Many precious things he said to me, but as a father, perhaps it might be attributed to weakness, or an inordinate affection for a son, if I made any remarks. 'Tis however very pleasing to me that his dear Aunt was enabled to seize a few opportunities, secretly, to pen down some of those words which fell from him at times. A few only, can be asserted here, but which plainly indicates the work of grace upon his heart, by the confession of his lips, and sweetly proving, that out of the mouth of this dear child God had ordained his own glory.

The contents of the following letter, sent to me by his Aunt, I beg leave also to insert, without a single comment of my own.

DEAR BROTHER,

Believing you would be desirous of knowing the dealings of the Lord with your dear child, I have endeavored to preserve a small part of what fell from his lips during the last weeks of his afflicted life. I say a small part, because the whole, had it not been for the necessary and close attention to his person, would have swelled a volume.

Previous to the time when he was confined to his bed, which was the latter end of December, when I had an opportunity to set with him, he would often talk on divine subjects, and appeared deeply interested in the things that pertained to his own salvation. He mentioned several sermons he had heard Dr. Andrews, of Walworth, preach, but particularly one, from, Oh my Dove, that art in the cleft of the rock. He ran through the several ideas that was advanced, with great correctness and interest. At another time when we were conversing about eternal things, he said, Aunt, I should not be

afraid to die, if I was sure I had an interest in Christ! You know it is possible to be deceived, and many people are. I never said so much to any one as I have to you. I talked to my dear father, and he answered me much the same as you have.

About the middle of February, when helping him out of bed, very helpless, and in great pain, he said, Aunt, I seem to have a hope that I shall be saved! Do you not think that answer to prayer is some evidence? and I am sure that many of my poor simply prayers have been answered.

February 26.—He held a truly interesting conversation with his Uncle, expressing the strongest desire to know if he was truly drawn to Christ! On the evidences being given to him, he appeared much refreshed, and said, It may be when I am nearer to death that the Lord may give me a full assurance. He often said how good the Lord is; I have more to be thankful for than to complain of! Once he said, Well Aunt, who can tell but the Lord may cure me? and if he does not, he will do a great deal better for me!—But for want of time, I must omit many very blessed things, and relate what more particularly transpired towards the close. The few last days in February, and the first and second of March, he was in great pain, and there was an evident alteration for the worst. In the night of the second of March, he said, Oh! affliction! affliction! My poor body is quite worn out! Oh! I wish for more patience and resignation. Aunt, I had rather lay here, with all my pains, than be running about the streets, in health, like many boys I know, cursing and swearing, and sinning against God. In the same night, he said, Oh! I hope we shall meet in Heaven! On my expressing the same hope, he cried out, Ah! but I want more than hope! I want assurance! Oh! I hope the Lord will sanctify this affliction.

Lord's day, March the third.—He asked me to read. After reading the word, and some hymns, he smiled, and said, How precious that is! I wish you had nothing else to do but to talk and read to me. In the evening of that day, he was in great pain. From twelve at night till three in the morning, his tongue was like the pen of a ready-writer. I said to him, My dear, have you long had serious thoughts about your soul? He answered, No, Aunt, not any thing particularly, till within a twelvemonth. How was it at the beginning with you? Why, I was very much alarmed for fear I should go to hell! I used to have such dark horror on my mind as I cannot describe! I used to

cry till I fell asleep, and then I used to dream it was the day of judgment, and wake very much terrified! I dreamt this a great many times. I cannot tell you what I went through, with the dark horror at day, and the terrifying dreams at night. Did you not feel at times, hopes springing up, that the Lord would save you, through Christ Jesus? Yes, very often, when I have been hearing my father, and Dr. Andrews, but afterwards I have been much distressed, for fear they were not right hopes. I never talked about what I felt. I thought people might think as I was a child that I heard a great deal about religion, it was what I had picked up—then added, with a strong voice and great satisfaction, But I know that what I picked up *then*, does me good *now*! Aunt, the last time I sung that hymn, Ah! I shall soon be dying, I never sung so in my life! I sung and cried! I sung as if I had another voice besides my own—I was so full of joy.—I spoke to Him of the great love of God, in calling him to the knowledge of himself, and bringing him to Jesus, for life and salvation. He replied, Oh! it is a great love. I keep you awake, but my heart is so full that I cannot help talking. This is but a small part of what passed on that, to me, memorable night.

March the 4th.—A young man was saying, when he was about thirteen years of age, he was so ill that used to pray to die. Samuel remarked after he was gone, That he did not know what death was, nor what it was to have a hell in his heart, or else he would not talk so.—Aunt, what a very precious hymn that is: All the fitness he requireth, is to feel your need of Him.—Oh! I hope I shall be able to say, as dear Mrs. Lawson said, when near death, I know in whom I have believed.—I hope my father will not grieve when I die—why should he? He often said, O that my warfare was ended.

March the 5th.—Very comfortable all day. About eleven at night, he suffered much. He said, Oh! I am quite worn out! I hope I shall not be long. It seems as if I could leave all now—Aunt, I can leave you! I hope I shall not suffer much at last—do you think I shall? I do not think you will my dear, but in all your sufferings the Lord will support you; you are not without sweet support now, are you? Oh, no! I am greatly supported, What a mercy it is to have promises to rest on. Oh! I want to go—not so much to get rid of suffering, as to see Jesus, which is better. Adding, Aunt, this is a comfort to me, you will not be long after me, nor uncle neither.—Once, when holding him up in my arms, he feared I should let him fall and cried out, Hold me up, hold me up! After a short pause, in a very expressive

manner, said, Hold thou me up, and I shall be safe; and then to me, As thy day is, so shall thy strength be.

One day, he said, I have longed when I have seen people go down into the water to be baptized, to go too. He was answered, That there was no salvation in water. He replied, Oh! I know that, but you know it is so sweet to follow the Lord! At another time, he said, Aunt, I have a secret hope, that if I was to recover, the Lord would never let me forget his goodness to me; these afflictions would be useful to me through life. Once, when in great pain, he said, Its only weaning—I want a great deal of weaning. Oh what a mercy to be reconciled to the will of the Lord. The Lord is very good.

The following Saturday, when lifting him into bed, he said, Oh! Aunt, may the Lord give me patience, and you strength. I answered, I believe he will. And though we could not see the end of the Lord, in thus afflicting him, yet if not before, we should in the light of glory. He answered, What a mercy to know we are going there. I hope my dear you know for yourself, you are going there? He replied with great firmness, Yes, I can say I believe I am. —And last night (alluding to some hours of great pain and agony) he said, If I could have spoken, though my poor body was so much afflicted, and my patience almost gone, I could have said, I know I am going to glory! He added, If I am not deceived, I hope I am not. Oh! what a great thing to be reconciled to the will God. Oh! pray for me, that I may have more patience to hold out.

March 26.—For several hours in great extremity of pain, but declared himself happy in soul.—Something having been said about faith, he answered, Ah! it is easy enough to talk about faith, but to be afflicted as I am, then we see how little faith we have got. Oh! Aunt, pray for me? Ask the Lord, Oh! do, do! Observe, this latter expression, Ask the Lord, was continually his request. I once said to him, then you believe the Lord heareth prayer? He answered with great quickness, Yes, and answering too. Being encouraged not to fear, he said, But sometimes I have fears! But why art thou cast down, Oh my soul? This day, when much distressed in body, he said, But why should I complain? What did the Lord suffer?

He sunk beneath our heavy woes
To raise us to a throne;
There's not a gift his hand bestows,
But cost his heart a groan!

March 28.—He said, Aunt, I am not desirous to live, but I hope I shall not go off in agony. Oh! Oh! let me be the subject of your prayers, continually! Oh! spend all your time in wrestling for me.

Lord's day, March 31.—In the afternoon a few friends came to see him, and a few hours he was cheerful, and free from pain. About ten, his pains became intolerable. It was a time of great distress. Between eleven and twelve, he became more easy, and a sweet colour appeared in his countenance. He said, Aunt, when I am in glory I shall sing as loud as any one, The crowned Lord of all. Oh! I long to go—I long to be singing hallelujah! He then sung Hallelujah, hallelujah! He then repeated the whole of the hymn, Grace, 'tis a charming theme; laying a particular emphasis on the words, Wrote my name—repeating (*My name*). Oh! I long to be singing. Crown him Lord of all! Calling to his Uncle in the next room, to come, Crown him Lord of all! On its being complied with, he joined with the sweetest voice. On our retiring to the next room, he sung alone, in a soft voice, a great part of the hymn, called Gethsemane. He then called, Uncle; come and sing again? On his replying, My dear; I am very low, he said, never mind, I will help you! He then sweetly joined in, Grace, 'tis a charming sound. At the conclusion, he said, It is all of grace. Oh! I long to Crown him Lord of all! He requested his Uncle to go to prayer? When concluded, he shook him by the hand, saying, I thank you, I thank you.—Monday.—Extremely low all day. On turning him in bed, he said, Oh! what should I do without you? but instantly added, in a louder voice, What should I do without the Lord?

Tuesday, April 2nd.—A day full of pain and distress indeed. About noon, he said, I shall not be long here! I expressed a hope of meeting him in glory. He answered, Yes, I do not fear that. I replied, yes, for He is able to save to the uttermost. He replied, If he has not saved you, he never will—adding, Saved from the beginning of the world! What a mercy Aunt, to be in Christ?—Wednesday.—Very low all day. Several times in the day he expressed a desire to depart, and be with Christ. He cried out, Oh! this poor

sinful body—a body of sin and death!—Late at night, he sighed, and said, Lord, what is man!—Thursday.—Suffered much all day. About noon, he said, To-morrow is Good Friday—Ah! what did the Lord suffer for us? And in a very emphatic manner, said, Oh Gethsemane!—Friday.—Evidently much worse. About noon he was very restless. I said, My dear, who can place your pillow easy? He replied, Only one God—must be my physician. About noon, he said, Oh! pray to the Lord to take me very soon? Then you are willing to go to him? He replied, Yes, before tea time, if it was the Lord's will! Oh that I could fall asleep in his arms. Oh! wrestle Aunt, Oh! wrestle! On uttering a few short petitions in his behalf, he affectionately thanked me, saying, Oh that our united prayers may be answered. About three o'clock, he said, Oh! why doth he tarry so long? Oh that *his chariot* was waiting for me! On assuring him that was the case—that the holy angels were surrounding him, to convey him before the throne of God and the Lamb, he cried, Oh that he would come quickly! Oh! to hear the sound of his chariot wheels! Why doth he tarry so long? When about to fall asleep in his arms, he whispered:

Cease fond nature, cease thy strife,
Let me languish into life.

The remainder of the evening spent in great pain, but fervent expressions after the coming of the Lord, often crying, Oh! ask the Lord why is his chariot so long in coming! About three in the morning, he fell into a sleep, and without pain or groan, sweetly fell asleep in Jesus.

Thus terminated the life of this believer in Jesus. May you, and I, and all his dear friends, be partakers of the like precious faith. Amen.

Your's, most affectionately,

E. Bonner.

Farewell, my dear son—and while I embalm thy memory with tears, a Gospel hope points me to a time when I shall meet you again, in the sacred blissful presence of a reigning Saviour, and a smiling God. Amen.

FINIS.

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